

Chapter 1 -- Before I Remember

"My Grandfather", she begins, "fled from France after Napoleon's disaster at Waterloo. He settled in the Mississippi Territory and, along with many other of the Little Emperor's Supporters, did all he could to further the plot to bring Bonaparte to New Orleans from St. Helena. After Napoleon's death, he decided to stay in the New World. In 1817 he claimed a large tract of land near Natchez on the Mississippi River; married that same year and in the following year, my Father was born, christened impressively William Louis Marshall Savoy, so named for one of Napoleon's fine Marshalls. When he was eight years old, his mother was killed when a wagon in which she and grandfather were riding overturned. Grandfather married a year later (1826) and after two unhappy years with an uncongenial stepmother, Father decided to run away from home. He packed a few clothes and a small supply of food in a flour sack, improvised a crude raft and, accompanied by a younger sister, floated down the Mississippi river. Two days later, hungry and tired, they beached their log raft near a beautiful colonial mansion which seemed to promise refuge. Thus Father began a life of adventure—a saga which would take him to some of the farthest reaches of the universe."

"The owner of the beautiful mansion took them in, these two nondescript children, who refused to divulge their parents names, and adopted them. Thus, reared and educated in a perfect environment, they probably had a better start in life had they not run away! Father was a brilliant youngster, of dashing and distinguished appearance, who grew rapidly into a handsome, aquilined-featured man. In 1840, at the age of 22, he became a government surveyor. Nine years later (1849), he went to California in the gold rush. He struck it rich and in 1851, tiring of the hectic and dangerous life in the gold fields, returned to Mississippi. Twice on this journey he was robbed by Mexican and Indian Outlaws—once at Eagle Pass and later near San Antonio. He was unharmed both times and, sensibly, had sent his gold ahead of him by safer means."

"When the Civil War began in 1861, he enlisted as a soldier in the Confederate Army but during the training period he injured a foot so severely that he gave up the idea of active service. He secured a transfer to the Intelligence Department and in the capacity of a spy, carried on for the South. He never told me of any tight spots or exciting adventures experienced during his secret service work. After the war he could not settle down to the routine life on a plantation. Thus began a five year search for new places, new experiences, more wealth. He never said much more than that (about) his travels except that he crossed the Atlantic twice and the Pacific three times. He did say, I remember, that he tried a venture in South America which was wrecked by a yellow fever epidemic. He fled on a ship and the whole crew—there were no passengers – of 19 men succumbed to Cholera. He credited his living to taking massive doses of calomel, a procedure at which the unfortunate victims laughed. I shall never forget his cryptic account of the latter stages of the disaster. "I, he said sardonically, had to throw each man overboard after he died. I wondered if I would see them all gone. I did. I performed for each one a Ritual before dumping him into the sea. When the last had gone, the ship was becalmed. For three months I lived on that ship, lonelier and more forlorn than I have ever been before. Even when the rescuers came, I was

kept aboard, towed to port, and quarantined. Most of my gray hairs can be traced to that experience, he concluded."

"Upon his release, he went to Texas and claimed two thousand acres of land in North Texas. In an area located about 16 miles east of Sherman, he laid out a town in his honor. In that same year - 1874 - he married my Mother, Mrs Julia E. Davis, who many years later, told me about the prominence he enjoyed in this section of Texas. She said after their wedding and spending their honeymoon in Denison, they were welcomed back to Savoy by a band and practically the whole town."

"But marriage and five children by him and three she had by Dr. William Davis were not enough to keep him settled. In 1886 he went to New Mexico, bought an interest in a silver mine and stayed for so long that Mother feared that some tragedy had befallen him. Two years later he reappeared, a broken man - the victim of some tragic occurrence about which he was silent. No one ever knew what it could have been."

"His fortune was dissipated, it was apparent. A few months after his return from New Mexico, he went to West Texas and homesteaded 2300 acres near Eastland. He also claimed 640 acres in what is now the Ranger Oil Field. I won't allow myself to think of how rich we would have become if he had been able to hold onto the Ranger claim. Due to back taxes, a faulty deed, prior claims, he eventually lost all of his holdings in this area. He never gave up. When he died 1889 at Joshua in Johnson County, Texas, of cancer of the stomach, he was fighting to recoup his lost wealth. Investigations after his death revealed that he was practically destitute. By that time we were old enough to carry on ourselves but for myself I would have almost preferred to know about all of his adventures than to have been left a small fortune!"

That is Mother's history of her father. Now in similar fashion, she told me what she knew about Robert A. Travis, my Father: "According to the accounts given to me by W. A. Caldwell, the son of one of the members of a family who knew your Father's family well, three Travis brothers came to the United States from England in the latter part of the 18th century. They landed in New York and during the ensuing years moved south and westward. Your Great Grandfather settled in the wilds of Tennessee Territory near Nashville where your Grandfather, William Travis, was born."

"In the year 1848 this William Travis, grown and married, migrated to central Mississippi and acquired a 640-acre section of land 6 ½ miles west of Canton, in Madison County. The Caldwells moved at the same time and claimed lands adjoining your Grandfather's. They owned slaves and cultivated their lands intensively and within a few years became prosperous. Their holdings became 'plantations' and they enjoyed life with slaves to wait on them, and by social activities with similar neighbors who had moved in and developed plantations. By 1851, the year your Father, Robert Anderson Travis, was born your Grandfather's plantation was moving along smoothly. He managed his slaves kindly and efficiently, he was well liked by his neighbors and was just getting everything running well when in the summer of 1854 he died of typhoid fever. Eight days later his wife succumbed to the same disease. Their tragic deaths - he

was 44 and his wife, Martha, was a few years younger -- left your Father, the youngest, and four other children orphaned. Fortunately Jim Caldwell and his sister Jane Caldwell, two refined people, took charge of the plantation and saw to it that these children were reared and educated properly."

"Your Father's education and growth to manhood were typical of that period of southern living. The plantation was well supplied with slaves and they did all of the tasks: tilled the soil, gathered and stored the crops, did all domestic duties in and around the 'Big House,' the owner's home. The plantation owner rode a fine horse over the 'place' to oversee the activities of his slaves, or had an overseer do this. Thus it was easy and natural for them to live lives of aristocrats and pursue whatever activities which struck their fancy. Your Father attended school, Coats Academy along with the children of other plantation owners. He grew up to enjoy live; picnics, dances, parties which they attended in styles and fashions of the era. Festivities were arranged so old and young could take part at the same time. It was very proper to go to Church on a regular and conscientious basis -- both on Sundays and on Wednesdays to prayer meetings."

"In 1861 the Civil War began but from what I could gather it did not affect his mode of existence appreciably. While many of the neighbors took part in the war, and some of the major action took place in Mississippi, notably at Vicksburg, and he was ten years old when it started luckily he and the Caldwells escaped harm. While the result of the war was that the slaves were freed, most of them elected to stay on the plantation and either worked for wages or on 'shares.'"

"So, Mr. Robert Travis continued to grow to manhood as a Southern Aristocrat. He rode fine horses, acted some as 'Overseer' as he got older, and led an active social life with the other young aristocrats. In his early 20's he fell desperately in love with Miss Alsworth. Her Father refused to allow her to marry him on the grounds that he loafed too much and drank a bit too much! Instead of changing his mode of living, he persisted in living the way he preferred and lost her. He and his gang kept up their way of life and, eventually, he got over her."

"As soon as he had grown up enough he took charge of the plantation, so his social life didn't keep him from being a success at that. The Negroes liked Mr. 'Bob' Travis very much and were willing to work hard for him. I marveled at his ability to get along with them so well and some of the slaves used to regale me with stories of the kind and thoughtful things he had done for them when they needed help."

"When he was 35 years old he married a Miss Ozzie Bilbo, a part Choctaw Indian. Miss Bilbo lived in Yazoo County, which adjoined Madison County, and while visiting in Canton, your Father met her. She was a very attractive young lady and created a sensation among the eligible young men there. Your Father was the lucky one. In the Spring of 1897 he moved his family to Caddo, Indian Territory. It seems that after his marriage, Charles Bilbo, his wife's brother, had gone to Indian Territory to claim lands granted to members of the Five Civilized Tribes -- Chickasaw, Choctaw, Cherokee, Creek and Seminole -- and your Father's move was to claim lands for Ozzie and their children: Robbie, Marie and William. He kept his Mississippi properties but decided it best to live in Indian Territory on the lands they had claimed successfully. Just as everything

was really getting organized and running smoothly, his wife died in 1898. This left him with Robbie, Marie and Will to rear. Robbie, the older girl, was no problem, for she wanted a formal education which suited him fine. Marie wanted a Business Training Course which he deplored, for in those days, young ladies didn't go into business! William just wanted to be a cowboy, which your Father deplored too. Mrs. Bilbo, the mother-in-law, sided with the children and did much to alienate them from your Father. She continued to meddle after your Father and I were married, but I will go into that later."

Here is Mother's story of her early life: "I was born in Savoy, Texas, on November 26th, 1874, the third of four children born to Julia E. Davis Savoy and Colonel William Louis Marshall Savoy. My Mother had had three children by her first husband, Dr. Davis, prior to his death. There were William, Irene and Emma. My brothers were Marshall, Joe and Ira. We grew up and were educated in Savoy. We were a closely knit family unit and our education, play, courtships, trials and tribulations were shared by all members of the family, and even to some extent by the inhabitants of this small, warm settlement. One of my most treasured memories is of my years attending 'Savoy Male and Female College,' which was conducted by and administered by Professor R. R. Halsell, a brilliant and scholarly man, to whom all who attended it owe a tremendous debt of gratitude. Young people today might consider it primitive but to me it still symbolizes the ultimate in educational institutions. Many of his graduates went on to make history in Texas and National affairs. He was brilliant in book knowledge but his outstanding characteristic was to inspire his students with lasting enthusiasms. Though I was handicapped by poor eyesight, even at times being unable to read all of my assignments, he inspired me to attain a more thorough education than any other teacher of mine, at any stage of my formal education. In later years it was a joy to go back to Savoy College for the reunions and to recall those glorious days with other graduates!"

"Of my brothers and half-sisters and half-brothers, none ever became famous or accomplished any outstanding record. As brilliant and accomplished and distinguished as my father was, he failed to pass these qualities on to us! The most promising of us was Ira. He was a dreamer and most resembled his Father. I remember his jumping up in the middle of the night to dash off some poetry, some of it exquisite. I kept much of it for many years but unfortunately lost it somewhere. But in 1898, when very young, he joined the army because of the Spanish American War and died of pneumonia in San Francisco, and was buried there in The Presidio. I have visited his grave and became very saddened while viewing it because he was my favorite and seemed to have such brilliant promise."

"Our social and other activities in those days would be considered tame to youth of 1935, but we had fun. We, of course, didn't have automobiles and radios and the other paraphernalia of today but we did many things in a quiet way and as I look back on it, we didn't miss out on so many tricks. There were dances, picnics, school parties, church socials. Going to church and to prayer meetings and Sunday School were an important part of our schedule. We had boyfriends and managed to do quite a bit of 'courting.' I was pretty much in the middle of everything. I fell deeply in love with a young man, who loved me equally, and one time we had a fight and before we 'made up' he died suddenly. It took me quite a while to get over this."

"Father's death in 1889 disrupted our lives economically, more than emotionally, because he was away from home so much that he was almost a stranger to use, he had always made lots of money. When it was discovered at his death that he was practically destitute, we suddenly found the need to get busy and provide a livelihood ourselves. The boys were old enough to get out on their own. Irene, my half-sister, married a Mr. Dodd, who owned a drug store in Caddo and moved there to live. I stayed at home to help Mother. In 1897 I married J. B. Rogers, Jr., and we lived in Farmersville. He was English, distinguished in appearance, distantly related to William Rogers, the silverware manufacturer, and an expert watchmaker and repairer. He was a sick man, suffering from catarrhal tuberculosis when we married, and he also had a drinking problem. His drinking undoubtedly hastened his death in 1902, after a prolonged period of illness. We were very happy while he lived and it was not a wasted or barren experience. Looking back on him after his death, I realized that I had married him out of sympathy. Mother was living with us at the time of his death and we stayed in Farmersville for the next two years where I taught a small class of private pupils of grammar school age and also had a number of guitar students, but it was a precarious way to make a living in such a small town."

"Mr. Travis, your Father, came into the picture in 1904 while I was on a visit in Caddo to see Irene. How did I meet him? He told me after we were married that he had seen me walking on the street there and without a moment's hesitation said to himself, 'There is the woman for me!' However, we were not introduced until several months later because I left Caddo. Caddo was a small place and it wasn't difficult to find out who I was so on my next visit there, he found me!"

At this point in Mother's narrative I asked her, "Had you noticed him that first time on the street in Caddo?"

"Yes."

"Did you think, 'There is the man for me'?"

"Of course not!! I did notice him though because he was a very attractive man."

"We began to see each other frequently while I was in Caddo and corresponded after I went back to Farmersville. That we didn't write just about the weather, we got married on November 26 – My 29th birthday – 1905 in Sherman, Texas. So he kept his promise to himself, but I won't deny that I had 'something to do with it!'"

"After a short honeymoon, we lived in Caddo with Robbie, Marie, William and Mrs. Bilbo – 3 stepchildren and an obnoxious mother-in-law! Robbie married soon after to Will McBride, a nice man, and left. In a short time trouble really began, because Mrs. Bilbo had created such a hostile atmosphere that it soon became unbearable. Mr. Travis was busy filing the land claims so he was not aware of the seriousness of the situation. I tried everything within reason to effect a happy family situation, but nothing worked. Meanwhile, you were about to be born so I just went along from day to day until your birth on October 5, 1906, at Caddo. You were a fine, lusty boy! After regaining

my strength I decided that the situation was unbearable. I couldn't get your Father to face up to the problem, so I decided when you were 7 months old to move to Douglas, Arizona. I was heart-broken but you were such a healthy, energetic young ruffian that I got strength from you! Uncles Marshall and Joe were living in Douglas and using Mexicans chiefly to build homes and stores. Though surprised to see me – I hadn't given them much warning – they welcomed me with open arms, which I needed. Douglas was a typical bordertown of that era, rough, ready, but they were able to take care of themselves and us. After a few months, I became more reconciled to the situation, grew stronger physically and psychologically, in the bracing Arizona climate. You continued to be healthy and vigorous. Uncle Marshall bought us a bicycle and put a basket on it, so I would take us for bicycle rides around Douglas and over the border into Agua Prieta, a small Mexican village and safe enough during the daytime." (Years later I went to Douglas in the camper and walked across the border, just to get a picture of what it could have been like in 1907.)

"it was fun riding the bicycle, you liked the view from your basket, and it was excellent exercise for me. In the meantime I corresponded with your Father, taking the position that what he did was up to him, but that I would not come back to Caddo. Finally, he decided that you and I were more important to him than were Mrs. Bilbo and Marie and William, so he came to Douglas to live. I shall never forget the hard time he had fitting into the wild and wooly atmosphere! It proved to be more than a Southern Gentleman could bear, so we went back to Caddo to take care of some business affairs and then onto the plantation near Virilia, Mississippi, in the Spring of 1907."

"It was a dreary situation, with rain, muddy roads, many Negroes around, rattling around in a large plantation home, 6 ½ miles out from Canton, a place, nice enough itself, of about 3000 people estimated. After Arizona with its dry, though warm climate, it was understandable that I was disappointed. But my disappointment could not withstand Mr. Travis' enthusiasm. The minute he got back he was a 'new man.' His whole being seemed to say, 'I am home, at last!' He went to work with a vengeance, painting and renovating the plantation house in which we lived. The Negroes called it the 'Big House.' It became a glistening white Colonial home, on a small scale. The Negro quarters were renovated, the land cultivated and the cotton and corn planted. The Negroes seemed to worship him, so they worked with enthusiasm. In late Spring, we had more and more sunshine and I began to see how he could be so enthusiastic about it. It became a drowsy paradise. Life on this place became a perfect experience and I look back on the years from 1907 to 1912 as being the happiest of my life. Marie and William continued to live in Oklahoma (it became a state in 1907) so they were no problem. On January 2, 1909, I gave birth to Lee Savoy and it was a terrible ordeal due to the ineptness of a country doctor and the fact that I was weakened by malaria. But Lee was OK and I came out of it in good shape. "

"As I became more and more accustomed to 'Southern Living,' with its quiet and lazy dignity, the more I savored it. I began to wonder if the wildness and primitive life in Douglas was so 'ideal' after all. We had Negroes to do 'everything': cook, wash, farm, whatever. And they were 'happy,' despite that the Civil War had been over for many years and they were 'liberated.' They weren't slaves officially, but in reality, they lived the same as they did as slaves. We went into Canton in a Surrey, had good horses

to ride over the place, for Mr. Travis to 'oversee' and for me to ride for pleasure. As you grew up, you and Lee romped all over the place. You played with the little Negroes and many times I yelled myself hoarse trying to get you to come home from the Negro quarters, or to stop throwing dirt or dust on a wretched pickaninny, or to get you out of the rain, or to stop doing other things that two white ruffianly-inclined brats could find to do on a 640-acre plantation. One time you ran away after some fancied wrong and some Negro brought you in from near the Virilia Store where you had lost yourself. You were pretty terrified by this experience and I don't remember you ever 'running away' again. I was miffed at your Father for not taking your disappearance more seriously, but he said, 'Nothing could have happened to the little rascal,' and left it at that. You were both healthy youngsters but you did catch some of the children's diseases: measles and whooping cough and some others but recovered without any damage. When you were ill, it kept me very busy and I wondered how a Mother could take care of 5 or 10 children as many of the Negro parents had."

"Aside from just playing with the Negroes, they were an important influence in your early life. With servants in the house to cook, make up beds, help dress and bathe you, to call you 'Big Boss' and Lee 'Little Boss.' We had several servants in the house over the early years. Then Aunt Elle Cross came and she was a remarkable person in every way. We first had her in a relief role and she was obviously just what we needed! She, her husband and one son lived on the place and were share croppers. She became a member of the family. She was in her sixties, small, bustingly energetic, clean, efficient, kindly disposed and so 'worldly-wise'! But she was a scrapper too, and I've seen her rear up and fight like a tigress when the situation demanded it! She was an important influence in your lives and deserves much credit for your turning out to be upstanding sons! She stayed on with us after Mr. Travis died and was a great help to me in keeping the farm going. It is difficult for me to find words to express fully my high regard and appreciation for this remarkable woman!"

"There were Negro men too who cannot be forgotten. Several of them lived on the place and worked for Mr. Travis for years, farming by either renting, share-cropping or for wages. The ones working for wages usually spent time around the house cutting wood, drawing water from our well, gathering corn, mowing and stacking or baling hay, repairing fences, digging ditches, maintaining roads. The renters paid rent for their quarters and might work away from the farm, at the Gin at Virilia, for example. The share croppers lived in the quarters, had their own mules and plow and split their crop with us. The 'Quarters' was a group of cabins located close to each other and most of the families had many children, with pickaninnies overrunning the area. Much of the time when you played with them you would get so covered with dust that it was hard to tell you and Lee from them."

"One of the leading Negroes on the place was Marion 'Man' Davis. He was lazy, loutish, easy going, with a family of eight or nine children by his own wife and probably some by other Negroes' wives! He was a sanctimonious profligate and was always to be found on the mourner's bench at Mount Hope Church. He was really 'good at heart' and after Mr. Travis' death, I relied on him very much. Samson Diamond was another, of an entirely different type. The other Negroes called him a 'smart' Negro. He was a hard worker, good at operating machinery and handling jobs that required

intelligence and versatility. Though I was never able to catch him, I am convinced that he was a clever and resourceful thief. I finally had to run him off, which I should have done long before for he really began to filch more after Mr. Travis' death."

"There were many others, of various types and personalities, but 'Man' and Samson are good examples. With this many of them living so close together, they would get into cutting or shooting scrapes and on numerous occasions, at various hours of the night, usually, there would be a knock on our door and a muffled voice saying, 'Boss! Boss!' Mr. Travis would go to the door and invariably he was asked to call a doctor to come take care of a slashed or shot Negro. Afterward Mr. Travis would tell me, 'Tom's wife found Tom with Liza Williams tonight and cut him up pretty badly about the throat and chest and he has little chance of recovery.' Many of them carried razors or knives with them and quite a few bore scars evidencing that they had participated in cuttings."

"Much has been said and written about the Negro loutishness, and aimlessness and they are this way to a degree, but much of it is due to the setup in which they find themselves. The share croppers are usually industrious because the more they grow, the more they make. After Mr. Travis' death – and I'll tell you about that later – I was suddenly thrown in full charge of the place, so I really got an education in The Black Person. So, to a degree, I agree with a story told by a Southern writer who said that one day he came upon a Negro youth sitting on a fence and asked him what he did for a living. 'Nothing,' he replied, 'I lives with my father.' 'Well,' continued the writer, 'What does your father do for a living?' 'Nothing,' replied the youth."

"One of the clearest things I remember about you was the difficulty I had getting you to walk the first time. You were eighteen months old before we could get you to even make any effort to even stand upright. I was more worried about this than Mr. Travis. Since you had no visible impairments, he felt that in good time you'd just stand up and get going! You kept putting it off and got very proficient in scooting around on the floor in a inimitable style which was a marvel of locomotion! This not only got you from place to place, but it enable you to wear out most of your dresses or pants. You refused to walk – until one day I decided that maybe a good and firm whipping would motivate you. 'Young man,' I said very firmly while brandishing a large and sinister switch, 'If you don't get up and walk this instant, I am going to whip you long and severely!' Whereupon, you got up and walked away from me, without a word!"

"Another happening I remember is that you and Lee were playing in a field and I called for you to come home. You decided to crawl over a fence instead of going around as you usually did. You got over it all right, but Lee got caught in the barbed wire and began to yell and scream at the top of his voice. You were about 150 yards away and I must have covered the distance in 10 seconds! You and me were trying desperately but ineffectually to get him down, and the more he moved, the more the barbs scratched him, so the louder he yelled. We were able, or course, to release him, but even after he was on the ground, he continued to cry – much of it from being terrified at the situation. This taught you and him a lesson, and I don't ever remember your crawling through or over a barb wire fence after that."

"When you were about 3 ½ years old Marie and Robbie came to visit us. You and Lee got sick at the same time and when they arrived you were both in bed. I don't think that you got sick deliberately, but when they found out you were under the weather, they proceeded to buy candy, toys, clothes – just about everything you 'brats' could want! Before you were able to get out of bed – and this is the reason I think your illnesses were feigned – you made them promise to send you a train and some automobiles. Marie and Robbie were obviously enjoying watching you enjoy the gifts. They must have spent \$50.00! incidentally, after your Father left them in Caddo, they became 'friendly' and got back on good terms with him, though they continued to live in Oklahoma."

"Now as I look back on those years from the time we moved to Virilia from Douglas until the middle of April, 1912, were the happiest days of our lives. It was at that time that he told me casually, 'I have a peculiar swelling – a knot-like growth – in my throat. It is not particularly painful but it seems to be getting larger.' I felt it and advised him to see a doctor soon. The next week he saw a doctor in Canton, our family physician, who didn't seem to think it was serious, and would go away in time. With that he decided that it would heal itself. However this was not the case, so he went to see Dr. Roan, a cancer specialist in Wesson, Mississippi, who diagnosed it as cancer and said that it had been ignored much too long. He said that Mr. Travis should go to Kellam Hospital in Richmond, VA, for immediate expert treatment. I still remember how white and shaken your Father was when he reported this to us. Those ten months in Kellam Hospital must have been the most miserable of his life. We couldn't be with him for I had to oversee the place and you and Lee were getting to an age where you, Ira, and Lee very soon afterward, had to be in school."

"He wrote regularly and his letters were always optimistic, even though I learned later that he knew very early that he didn't have a chance of surviving. In September he wrote, 'I am getting better and the doctors think I can be released in a couple of weeks.' His cheerfulness was what kept me going: I ran the place, managed the Negroes, borrowed money from the bank at his behest to meet all expenses, confident that he would be back with us any week to take charge. Harvest time rolled around, winter came and he wrote how beautiful the snow was in Richmond. Spring came and I began to doubt his optimism. He died June 25, 1913, in the hospital and was buried in the Family Graveyard located about a mile north of the Big House."

"You begin to remember now, don't you, some of these things?"

"Yes," I replied. This was true, but some of my memories were, then, hazy. I was approaching 70 years of age and from then on I do remember more clearly, so I'll start the next Chapter – I Begin to Remember.